05_visa-thailand-dtv-research

THAILAND DTV — DEEP RESEARCH DOSSIER

Research date: 4 October 2026 **Subject:** David Atanu (Nigerian, 30) + Sarah (Nigerian, 31, not yet married) **Status:** Research complete. Three load-bearing items unverified — see §7.

0. HEADLINE: THE RULE CHANGE THAT REWRITES THIS PLAN

On **28 August 2026** Thailand's Department of Consular Affairs announced changes effective **31 August 2026**. The e-Visa portal was taken offline on 30 August and reopened under new rules.

#	Change	Effect on David
1	Must apply at the Thai mission covering **country of citizenship or permanent/legal residence**. Third-country applications ended.	**Must apply in Nigeria (Abuja).** Vientiane / Ho Chi Minh / Kuala Lumpur / London routes are closed to him unless he holds legal residence there.
2	**Proof of permanent residence** replaces proof of current location	Nigerian residence proof needed; definition left undefined by MFA → embassy divergence
3	**Police clearance certificate mandatory for all DTV applicants**	New document, on top of Nigeria's existing NDLEA certificate
4	Thai language courses removed as a soft power activity	Closes the cheapest soft power option

The announcement **did not define** what qualifies as proof of permanent residence, producing open inconsistency between missions (Vientiane: nationals/PRs of Laos only; Los Angeles: a driving licence or valid US visa suffices; Moscow: contradicts itself between its English and Russian pages).

Strategic consequence: the single biggest lever David had — picking a lenient embassy — is gone. His application now stands or falls at Abuja.

1. THE TWO QUALIFYING ROUTES COMPARED

Dimension	(a) Workcation / Remote Work	(b) Thai Soft Power
Official document trigger	"Employment contract or employment certificate in their country **or professional portfolio** showcasing digital nomad, remote worker, foreign talent or freelancer status"	"Letter of acceptance from institute or company organizing activities, letter of appointment from hospital/medical centre"
Fit for a self-employed retail trader	**Weak.** No employer, no payslips, no client contracts. Several embassies additionally demand 6 months of salary slips and an embassy-authenticated company registration.	**Strong.** Work status is irrelevant; only funds + enrolment matter.
Burden sits with	The applicant (must manufacture a credible work paper trail)	The Thai provider (school/gym/hospital supplies the pack)
Reported 2025–26 direction	Tightening hard against self-employed	Tightening on course *duration*, not on applicant status
Known failure mode	"Self-employed without clear income" being rejected	Course too short (<6 months) → METV issued instead of DTV
Verdict for David	Second choice at best	**PRIMARY ROUTE**

Why workcation is the wrong door for a prop-firm trader

- **ask.in.th, stock traders:** "If you are just a retail platform trader I doubt it." Thai immigration has published no criteria for individual traders.
- **ask.in.th, forex/share trading income:** "That will likely be tricky unless you have a registered company."
- **petchnumnoi.com (Aug 2026):** applicants "without actual jobs (or who apply as self-employed without clear income) are being rejected, whereas those with employment have smoother approvals."
- **Thailand Starter Kit / ExpatDen (2026):** salaried remote workers approved at higher rates than self-employed. Vague "I work online" letters are rejected.
- **ASEAN NOW, member `rkh_`:** advises *avoiding* the workcation pathway entirely in favour of soft power.

On the specific instruments David holds:

- A **prop-firm funded-account agreement** is untested in any source found. It is not an employment contract — it is an evaluation/profit-split agreement that typically disclaims an employment relationship. **Unproven, not proof.**
- **Trading own capital** is the weakest case: no counterparty, no invoices, no client.
- A **registered company** with its own registration certificate, corporate tax filing and cover letter is the single highest-value upgrade to a workcation case.
- A **portfolio** works where it shows a *public, multi-year body of work*. The one documented portfolio-only approval (London, 2024) was a vlogger with a 4–5 year website of videos, podcasts and articles. **A brokerage equity curve is not that.**

Soft power: activity list and documentary burden

Activity	Appears on	Status
Muay Thai training	Every mission checked; Cairo lists it as the *only* activity	Core, best established
Thai culinary / cooking	Singapore, Washington DC, Moscow, Phnom Penh	Core
Medical treatment	Singapore, Washington DC, Moscow, Phnom Penh	Core
Sports training	Phnom Penh, KPMG summary	Listed, less tested

Seminars	Phnom Penh, KPMG	Listed, less tested
Music festivals	Phnom Penh, KPMG	Listed, less tested
Thai massage	terms.law (legal commentary)	Reported active, not on official lists
Buddhism / meditation	terms.law	Reported active, not on official lists
Thai language courses	—	**DISCONTINUED.** Use Non-Immigrant ED instead.

Activity	What the applicant must produce
Thai cooking	School enrolment letter with dates; school business licence; payment receipt. **School packages all of it.**
Medical treatment	Hospital letter of appointment or treatment plan with timeline; hospital business licence. **Single institution, lowest paper count.**
Muay Thai	Gym acceptance letter + receipt + Sports Authority of Thailand registration + head-coach licence + instructor certificates + company registration + DBD certificate + gym photos/map/curriculum + owner's Thai ID + VAT registration. Some posts still ask for the legacy Board of Boxing Sport letter (3–4 month waiting list).

Lowest documentary burden: terms.law (Dec 2025) rates **medical treatment** simplest, "High" approval. In practice **Thai cooking is lowest-effort for the applicant** because reputable schools assemble and warrant the whole pack. **Muay Thai** carries the heaviest provider stack but is best understood by officers.

COURSE DURATION IS THE REAL GATE:

Duration	Outcome
Under 3 months	~99% rejection
6 months	"Bare minimum"; several embassies now issue a multiple-entry *tourist* visa instead
9–12 months	**Current safe standard**
South Asia / Middle East posts	Assume 12 months minimum (Dhaka demands 1 year)

Worked example: **Arun Thai Cooking** — 9-month minimum, ≥1 class/week (45–60 classes), **THB 48,900** for 9 months / THB 58,900 for 12 months, plus optional THB 9,500 visa-support package.

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2. DOCUMENT CHECKLISTS

Common to both routes (post-31 Aug 2026)

1. Passport, valid 6+ months, blank pages
2. Recent photograph (within 6 months; size varies by post)
3. Completed online application via **thaievisa.go.th** (Abuja accepts no physical applications)
4. Passport biodata copy
5. **Proof of permanent residence** in the country of application *(new)*
6. **Police clearance certificate** *(new)* — recency varies: London 6 months; Washington DC 3 months
7. **Bank statements, last 3 months, ending balance ≥ THB 500,000 each month**
8. Proof of accommodation in Thailand (some posts)
9. English or Thai translations, notarised/legalised
10. **Nigerian nationals: NDLEA Clearance Certificate** (see §5)

Route (a) Workcation — additional

- Employment contract or certificate from a foreign employer, **or** professional portfolio
- *Where demanded:* 6 months of salary slips / monthly income proof
- *Where demanded:* company registration, embassy-authenticated
- *Recommended:* 1–2 years of tax returns; client invoices reconciling to bank deposits; a specific cover letter

Route (b) Soft Power — additional

- Letter of acceptance stating course dates and duration (target 9–12 months)
- Provider's business registration / operating licence
- Payment receipt
- Medical: hospital letter of appointment or treatment plan
- Muay Thai: the extended provider stack above

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3. THE THB 500,000 FINANCIAL REQUIREMENT

Question	Answer
Current figure	**THB 500,000** — unchanged through the Aug 2026 tightening
Local equivalents	USD 16,000 (Washington), SGD 20,000 (Singapore), MYR 65,000 (KL), EGP 850,000 (Cairo)
Seasoning	**3 months minimum** — "ending balance of no less than 500,000 THB **for each month**". 6 months preferred at stricter posts
Whose name	The applicant's own
Joint account	Accepted at some posts if both names appear. Moscow expressly allows a "family joint statement with proof of relationship"
Currency	THB or foreign-currency equivalent with clear documentation

Account type	**Savings / current / withdrawable fixed deposit ONLY.** REJECTED: crypto, stocks, ETFs, brokerage/investment portfolios, pensions, property valuations, credit limits
Must it remain?	Not formally required at approval, **but** immigration can request proof on entry and requires updated proof at the 180-day extension. **Treat as permanently committed.**
Same 500k for principal + dependant?	**No — assume each person needs their own.** Singapore requires the dependant's own 3-month statement. Some posts accept a family statement at ~THB 1,000,000 total

THE DOMINANT REJECTION CAUSE IS THIS LINE ITEM. One operator attributes ~70% of refusals to bank-statement problems: "parked" money arriving shortly before filing, thin transaction history, wrong account type, or statements dated more than 30 days before submission.

For David, two risks compound: (i) funds held in brokerage/prop accounts **do not count** and must move to a bank well in advance; (ii) a trader's account shows volatile flows, so the statement must read as a coherent income story, not as unexplained large transfers.

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4. THE SPOUSE / DEPENDANT ROUTE (critical for Sarah)

Question	Answer
Who qualifies	**Legal spouse** and unmarried children under 20
Marriage certificate	**MANDATORY.** Translated and legalised. For Nigerian documents: certification by the Nigerian MFA, then legalisation by the Royal Thai Embassy Abuja. Missing legalisation is a commonly cited rejection cause.
Unmarried partners	**NO PROVISION. EXPLICITLY INELIGIBLE.** Girlfriends/boyfriends are not next of kin under DTV rules. **Sarah cannot be a dependant until they are legally married.**
Timing	**AFTER, not with.** The dependant's file must include the principal's *approved* DTV.
Fee	Full visa fee each — THB 10,000 or local equivalent
Dependant's financial proof	Own 3-month THB 500,000 statement at Singapore; family/joint statement at Moscow; sponsorship letter required at several posts
Sponsor letter	Required, with handwritten signature
Police clearance	Required of dependants too
Can a dependant work remotely?	**CONFLICTING.** One FAQ says yes (non-Thai employers only); another says no work rights. No official text. **UNRESOLVED.**
If the principal's DTV is cancelled?	**NO SOURCE FOUND, official or otherwise. UNRESOLVED.**

The strategic read on Sarah — three options, and the obvious one is not the dependant route

1. **Marry, then apply as dependant.** Requires marriage before filing, legalised certificate, David approved first, her own police clearance + NDLEA, plausibly her own THB 500,000, and a second fee. Slow, sequential, and leaves her status derivative of his — with the consequences of his cancellation unknown.
2. **Sarah applies independently under workcation.** Her freelance copywriting in USD produces exactly the evidence the workcation category asks for and David's trading cannot: **named clients, signed contracts, dated invoices, and bank deposits that reconcile to those invoices. Her case is structurally stronger than his.**
3. **Sarah applies independently under soft power.** Same route as David, independent of marital status and of his outcome.

Two independent DTVs cost THB 20,000 and two × THB 500,000 in seasoned funds, but they run **in parallel rather than sequentially, and neither collapses if the other fails.** Given the unknown around dependant status on cancellation, independence is the lower-risk structure.

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5. NIGERIAN-APPLICANT SPECIFICS

Which mission

Royal Thai Embassy Abuja — 34 Rhine Street, Maitama. Tel (+234) 706 308 0501. **consular.abj@mfa.go.th**

Jurisdiction: Nigeria, Benin, Cameroon, Chad, Republic of the Congo, CAR, Equatorial Guinea, Ghana, São Tomé and Príncipe. **No Thai consulate in Lagos in any official source.**

Post-31 August 2026, **Abuja is the only mission open to a Nigeria-resident Nigerian citizen.** And note: even where a Nigerian holds third-country residence, **the NDLEA requirement follows the passport** — Kuala Lumpur, London and Doha all impose it on Nigerian citizens regardless of where they file.

Mechanics

Item	Detail
Channel	Online only, **thaievisa.go.th**. Abuja "does not accept physical application"
Processing	**10 working days**, excluding submission day
When to file	4–6 weeks before travel; **do not** file more than 3 months before departure
Payment	**NAIRA DEBIT CARDS WILL NOT PROCESS.** An international Visa or Mastercard is required — resolve before filing
DTV fee	THB 10,000 base. The naira/USD figure at Abuja is unverified

NDLEA Clearance Certificate — Nigeria-only requirement

Required of Nigerian nationals for Thai visas generally; imposed by Abuja, Kuala Lumpur, London and Doha alike.

- Abuja's checklist: issued **not more than one year** before application

- Filing from outside Nigeria additionally requires Nigerian MFA certification + Royal Thai Embassy Abuja legalisation
- Apply at **drugandvisa.ndlea.gov.ng** · Fee **₦21,950** · Processing **3–7 working days**
- Needs: passport pages 1–6, NIN slip, state of origin certificate, typed signed application letter, **drug integrity test**, sponsor and guarantor documents. **The guarantor must reside in the applicant's state and cannot be a spouse or immediate family member.**

The new police clearance is a SECOND, separate document

The 31 August 2026 requirement is a criminal-record certificate — distinct from the NDLEA drug clearance. In Nigeria that is the Nigeria Police Force character certificate. **Exactly what Abuja accepts, and its recency, is unverified.** London requires issuance within 6 months, Washington DC within 3 — the window is tight and cannot be rushed at the counter.

Scrutiny

- Abuja's general visa regulations require applications **in person** for some categories and reference originals produced **at interview** — interviews are a live possibility
- Heightened passport-based scrutiny is reported for Israeli, Russian, Indian, Pakistani and Myanmar holders. **Nigeria is not named in any source found** — but the NDLEA regime is itself a nationality-specific burden, and the practical read is that a Nigerian file will be read closely

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6. FEES AND TIMES, AS AT OCTOBER 2026

Item	Amount
DTV visa fee	THB 10,000 (USD 400 Washington, SGD 500 Singapore, EGP 18,000 Cairo)
In-country 180-day extension	THB 1,900
NDLEA clearance	₦21,950
9-month Thai cooking course (example)	THB 48,900 (+THB 9,500 optional visa support)
Proof of funds (not a fee)	**THB 500,000 per person**
Processing — Abuja	10 working days
Validity	5 years, multiple entry, 180 days per entry, extendable once by 180 days

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7. COULD NOT VERIFY — item 1 is a go/no-go

1. **WHETHER THE ROYAL THAI EMBASSY ABUJA PROCESSES DTV APPLICATIONS AT ALL.** The DTV does **not appear** in Abuja's published visa regulations PDF or its document checklist form — both enumerate only Tourist (TR), Non-B, Non-ED, Non-O, Medical (MT), Transit (TS) and Diplomatic. No Abuja DTV page exists; attempts returned 404. Cairo — another African mission — *does* publish a DTV page, so there is no regional bar in principle. One third-party aggregator lists DTV as available to Nigerians (weak evidence). **Since 31 August 2026 there is no alternative mission. If Abuja does not issue DTV, the route is closed.** Resolve by emailing consular.abj@mfa.go.th before spending anything.
2. **What police clearance Abuja accepts, and its required recency** — whether the NPF character certificate suffices, and whether NDLEA satisfies it or is additional.
3. **Whether a DTV dependant may work remotely.** Sources contradict; no official text found.
4. **What happens to a dependant's DTV if the principal's is cancelled.** No source addresses it.
5. **The DTV fee as charged at Abuja** in naira or USD.
6. **Whether a prop-firm funded-account agreement has ever been accepted** as workcation evidence. No reported case either way.
7. **Whether Abuja requires an in-person interview for DTV** specifically.
8. **The authoritative soft power activity list.** Missions publish materially different lists (Cairo: Muay Thai only; Singapore/Moscow/Washington: three; Phnom Penh: six).
9. **Whether Thai language courses were excluded in 2025 or 2026.** The exclusion is the more recent and more consistent claim.
10. **Any announced plan to amend or withdraw the DTV.** Nothing found. The Royal Gazette basis (effective 15 July 2024) remains in force; 2026 activity is documentary tightening, not withdrawal. *Absence of evidence, not evidence of absence.*
11. **Current approval/rejection rates.** One operator publishes a 62–94% range by embassy; uncited and unverifiable, and those posts are closed to him anyway. **No data exists for Abuja.**

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8. RECOMMENDATION

Step	Action
0	**Email consular.abj@mfa.go.th and confirm Abuja issues DTV**, which police clearance it requires, the fee, and whether an interview applies. **Nothing else matters until this returns.**
1	Default to the **soft power route**, 9–12 month Thai cooking or Muay Thai enrolment with a provider that supplies a complete document pack. **Not workcation.**
2	Start **seasoning THB 500,000 per person now** — bank savings/current account, not brokerage or prop, with 6 months of clean traceable history by filing date.
3	Start **NDLEA and police clearance immediately** — NDLEA needs a drug integrity test and a non-family guarantor resident in his state; the police certificate has a 3–6 month recency window.
4	Obtain an **international Visa/Mastercard**. Naira cards will fail at payment.
5	**Prefer two independent applications** over the dependant route. Sarah's USD copywriting is a stronger workcation case than David's trading, and independence removes the unknown around dependant status on cancellation.
6	If a workcation case is ever built, **register a company** and file corporate tax returns first. A prop-firm agreement is not an employment contract.

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9. SOURCES

Official Thai government: Royal Thai Embassy London (visa general information, 31 Aug 2026 changes; Nigerian nationals page) · Royal Thai Embassy Doha (Nigerian nationals) · Royal Thai Embassy Abuja (visa regulations PDF; document checklist PDF; e-Visa notice) · Royal Thai Embassy Singapore (DTV soft power; DTV spouse and children) · Royal Thai Embassy Kuala Lumpur (DTV, NDLEA for Nigerians) · Royal Thai Embassy Washington DC · Royal Thai Embassy Phnom Penh · Royal Thai Embassy Moscow · Royal Thai Embassy Cairo · Thai MFA DTV checklist PDF · thaievisa.go.th · ndlea.gov.ng/visaclearance

Legal / professional: KPMG Thailand Tax News Flash 147 (Royal Gazette basis, 15 Jul 2024) · Envoy Global · Erickson Immigration Group · Siam Legal · Issa Compass · terms.law (Tokmakov), soft power categories, Dec 2025

Commercial guides and sector operators: Thailand Starter Kit / ExpatDen · thaiembassy.com · Muay Thai Fever (Aug 2026) · Petchnumnoi (Aug 2026) · Tiger Eye MMA · Arun Thai Cooking · StampStay · Muay Thai Visa Thailand · The Thaiger · Asia Lifestyle Magazine

Forum / anecdotal: ASEAN NOW (DTV application restrictions Sep 2026; rules vary between embassies; professional portfolio requirement; odd work status) · ask.in.th (stock traders; forex/share trading income; unmarried partner)

Flagged unreliable: japacalculator.com (asserts a Thai "High Commission" in Abuja and a "Consulate in Lagos" — both unsupported) · visamanager.io (third-party aggregator, no official corroboration)